

I46 Barabbas

The guilty prisoner who walked free while Jesus was crucified.

Barabbas was a prisoner in Jerusalem when Jesus was brought to trial. The Gospels call him a notable prisoner, a robber, and a man jailed for insurrection and murder. At Passover the Roman governor customarily released one prisoner the people asked for. Pontius Pilate, sure that Jesus was innocent, offered the crowd a choice between Barabbas and Jesus. Urged on by the chief priests, the crowd cried out for Barabbas. So a man who had taken life went free, and the man who gave life was led away to die. Scripture tells us nothing about Barabbas before his arrest or after his release. Yet his brief moment has made him one of the best-known names of the Passion.

At a glance

Name	Barabbas, from Aramaic words meaning "son of the father"
Charge	Sedition, or insurrection, and murder (Luke 23:19; Mark 15:7)
Also called	"A notable prisoner" (Matthew 27:16) and "a robber" (John 18:40)
Place	Jerusalem, in Roman custody
When	Released c. AD 30, at Passover
Key people	Pontius Pilate, the chief priests, the crowd, Jesus
Main passages	Matthew 27:15–26; Mark 15:6–15; Luke 23:18–25; John 18:39–40

*"Then cried they all again, saying, Not this man, but Barabbas.
Now Barabbas was a robber."*

John 18:40, KJV

The life of Barabbas

The date follows the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30; on the other main view, AD 33. Scripture tells us nothing about Barabbas before his arrest or after his release.

Before Passover Jerusalem	● Arrested
	An insurrection breaks out in the city, and murder is done in it. Barabbas lies bound in prison with others who took part in the uprising. <i>Mark 15:7; Luke 23:19</i>
c. AD 30 Passover morning	● Offered for release
	At the feast the governor usually releases one prisoner of the people's choosing. Pilate asks, "Whom will ye that I release unto you? Barabbas, or Jesus which is called Christ?" <i>Matthew 27:15-17; Mark 15:6-9</i>
The same morning	● Chosen by the crowd
	The chief priests and elders persuade the crowd to ask for Barabbas and to destroy Jesus. They cry out, "Not this man, but Barabbas." <i>Matthew 27:20-21; John 18:40</i>
The same morning	● Set free
	Pilate, "willing to content the people," releases Barabbas to them. He has Jesus scourged and hands him over to be crucified. <i>Mark 15:15; Luke 23:24-25</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Some early manuscripts of Matthew 27:16–17 call him "Jesus Barabbas," which would make Pilate's question a choice between two men named Jesus. The KJV does not include this reading, and scholars are divided about it.

- 1 **Joined an insurrection.** He was held with rebels who had risen up in the city. *Mark 15:7*
- 2 **Was jailed for murder.** Luke says he was in prison "for a certain sedition made in the city, and for murder." *Luke 23:19*
- 3 **Became a notorious name.** Matthew calls him "a notable prisoner," someone the crowd already knew. *Matthew 27:16*
- 4 **Was set against Jesus.** Pilate placed him beside Jesus and asked the crowd to choose. *Matthew 27:17*
- 5 **Went free in Jesus' place.** Pilate released the man guilty of sedition and murder, and delivered Jesus to their will. *Mark 15:15; Luke 23:25*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Barabbas.

Old Testament

Echo: Isaiah 53:5	"He was wounded for our transgressions"
Echo: Leviticus 16:7–10, 21–22	One goat dies, one goes free; some compare the choice

New Testament

Matthew 27:15–26; Mark 15:6–15; Luke 23:18–25; John 18:39–40	All four tell of the choice
Acts 3:14	Peter: they "desired a murderer to be granted unto you"
Echo: 1 Peter 3:18	"The just for the unjust"; Barabbas as every sinner freed is application, not text

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How do the Gospels describe Barabbas (Mark 15:7; Luke 23:19; John 18:40)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think the crowd chose Barabbas over Jesus?
3. *Apply:* Barabbas went free while Jesus died. How does that picture help you understand 1 Peter 3:18?
4. *Apply:* Scripture does not say what Barabbas did with his freedom. What is one way you will use your freedom in Christ to serve someone this week?